

Pakistan's GOOGLY

Pakistan snubs India again by letting off the mastermind of the Mumbai attacks

Hate crimes against Indian students in Australia was not the only concern giving South Block a headache. It is now in danger of developing a full-blown diplomatic migraine as the new government sets out repairing ties with neighbours. On June 2, the first signs of Pakistan's cussed approach were visible as a Pakistani court released the mastermind of the Mumbai attacks, Lashkar-e-Toiba (LET) ideologue Hafiz Mohammed Saeed, despite censure by the UN Security Council. India conveyed its displeasure over Saeed's release, when Foreign Secretary Shivshankar Menon met Pakistan's High Commissioner Shahid Malik on June 2.

India also told the US that this demonstrated Pakistan's lack of seriousness to fight terror and raised serious doubts about its commitment to probe the Mumbai attacks. Saeed was put under house arrest on December 11 last year after the UN banned the JuD, declaring it a front for LET. Saeed has also been chargesheeted in India for the Mumbai attacks. South Block sources say India will put more pressure on Pakistan by telling its international interlocutors that it has not done much to control terrorism, and that is where India draws the red line. "The prerequisite for resuming the dialogue process with Pakistan is that it has to dismantle terror infrastructure and take action against terrorist groups," said Krishna. Menon is equally emphatic, "Saeed's release demonstrates that the infrastructure of terrorism has not been dismantled." India has also pushed its case at the UN for proscribing four more terrorists, including Jaish-e-Mohammed chief Masood Azhar.

Even as US Under Secretary of State William Burns touches down to prepare the ground for a visit by US Secretary of State Hilary Clinton, the message from Delhi will be: No dialogue till Islamabad moves ahead on the terrorism issue. Realising that India will put pressure, Pakistan has strategically raised the bogey of Kashmir

again just ahead of the visit by top US diplomats to shift the focus away from the core issue of terrorism.

If the western border continues to simmer, the bout of uncertainty continues to prevail in Nepal, where India has carefully kept itself on the margins. In fact, a combined trip to Bhutan and Nepal may be the first port of call for Krishna in his pledge to reach out to neighbours. Bangladesh is yet to deliver on its promise of handing over some ULFA leaders to India, and in Sri Lanka, the humanitarian crisis may get out of hand if the Rajapakse Government is not able to keep its promise of devolution of powers and rehabilitate Tamil



**SAEED AT HIS RESIDENCE
AFTER HIS RELEASE**

refugees in their own villages soon. So for the new Government, the next few weeks pose multiple challenges. On Pakistan, India will have to ensure that the focus does not shift from the 26/11 investigations and a timeline is fixed so that the guilty are punished. To the rest of the neighbours, the message that will have to be delivered is that India will not play big brother but is ready to do business on an equal footing. If this stand is communicated effectively, this may be the best pain reliever for the new Government.

by Saurabh Shukla

INDIA WILL NOT RESUME THE DIALOGUE PROCESS TILL PAKISTAN DISMANTLES ITS TERROR SET-UP.